## THE MYANMAR UPDATE SERIES AND THIS VOLUME

The first Myanmar Update conference was held at the ANU in 1990. Since 2004 the conferences have been organized on a regular, biannual schedule. Over this period, the conferences have become the most significant events of their kind, drawing practitioners, analysts, and academics from around Australia, from Myanmar, and from across the world. The 2015 event was particularly notable. Khin Aung Myint, the speaker of the Union Assembly's House of Nationalities from 2011 to 2016, delivered the keynote address. For him, it was a very rare speech in English and an opportunity to explain the challenges of the transition from military rule. Years earlier it would have been inconceivable that such a senior retired military figure could even travel to Australia, let along participate in an academic event that prides itself on free expression and open debate. To his credit, Khin Aung Myint relished the chance to present his views and take questions from all-comers. We hope that future events will be similarly open to high-level political figures from among Myanmar's changing group of leaders.

In 2015, the Myanmar Update grappled directly with the dynamics of ongoing conflict and contention. The Buddhist–Muslim faultline was the subject of sustained and sometimes heated discussion. The issue of Muslim refugees taking to the Andaman Sea in search of safer harbour ensured the audience left with a strong impression of the real world implications of academic debate. The Myanmar Update conference series has long sought to engage with Myanmar's difficult political, economic and social conditions with a keen eye to practical consequences. This tradition now offers a rising generation of scholars, analysts and practitioners a chance to test their ideas and to seek out the most effective solutions to prevailing problems. Focusing attention on Myanmar's conflict dynamics is yet another way of showcasing our consistent attention to the most pressing political concerns.

Over the past decade each conference has been followed by academic publications, usually in the form of an edited volume. We are delighted that this volume includes a wide range of authors, drawn from across generations, national backgrounds and political perspectives. Taken together, the authors showcase the value of considered academic reflection on contemporary events and the need for creative responses to entrenched issues. The grim reality is that, for generations to come, Myanmar's development will feel the reverberations of conflict. Even when peace is